



BEFORE

During the War with Mexico (1846–48), the American military attached civilian volunteer units to a core of permanent army professionals.

PERMANENT FORCE

Zachary Taylor commanded an army in northern Mexico in 1846 composed of regulars, while Winfield Scott relied on a permanent veteran core in the force he used to conquer Mexico City.



165 The number of steps per minute soldiers would march at “double quick time,” the swiftest pace used by American infantry tactics.

For the North, the 16,000-man U.S. Army of 1860 could not serve as the bedrock of a new field army, because the force still needed to guard the frontier. About one-quarter of its officer strength resigned and traveled South. **The Confederacy, in contrast, had to build a new army from scratch** (see [Raising Armies](#)).

MEXICAN TRAINING GROUND

While Scott was now too old to take the field, many Civil War commanders (including Grant and Lee) had **earned valuable combat experience** during the War with Mexico.

After Bull Run, Union forces had to face the deficiencies of their organization. General James B. Ricketts argued that at Bull Run, “The men were of as good material as any in the world, and they fought well until they became confused on account of their officers not knowing what to do.” Perceptions of officer incompetence led to officer examination boards for weeding out the worst leaders, and by March 1862 the boards had expelled 310 officers from the Army.

While the Confederate armies also used the winter after Bull Run to cull weak officers, and train and organize others, overly romantic views of warfare persisted. Shortly after the battle, the Richmond *Examiner* declared that “Ohio and Pennsylvania ought to feel ... the terrors which agitate the cowardly and guilty when retributive vengeance is at hand ... In four weeks our generals should be levying contributions in money and property from their own towns and villages.”

Unfortunately for the Confederacy, overheated rhetoric could not by itself produce armies capable of offensive operations in the North. The South should have used the winter to mobilize its national resources through measures such as conscription, but instead waited until the spring, when Confederate fortunes began to slide.